

The Civil Rights Movement

Weigh what changed, what changed slowly, and what stayed the same across the Civil Rights Movement (1954–1968), and judge whether it was a true turning point.

? Historical challenge

Between 1954 and 1968, courts, laws, and mass movements dismantled the legal framework of segregation. But law on paper and life on the ground are not the same thing. Compare before, during, and after — then judge: was this era a genuine turning point in U.S. history, or the acceleration of a longer struggle?

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Civil Rights Act (1964) – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The 1964 law banning discrimination and outlawing segregation in public accommodations and employment.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did the Civil Rights Act make illegal?
- What might a law like this not be able to change by itself?

SOURCES 2

Voting Rights Act (1965) – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The 1965 law outlawing literacy tests and authorizing federal oversight of voter registration.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did this law try to protect the right to vote?
- Why might voting rights need federal enforcement?

SOURCES 3

Little Rock Central High School National Historic Site – National Park Service

SECONDARY SOURCE

How nine Black students integrated a school in 1957 and why federal troops were sent.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did it take to enforce the court's desegregation order?
- What does this show about the gap between law and practice?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

THE EVENT

The Civil Rights Movement

1954–1968

The United States

Before

Jim Crow laws and legally enforced segregation across the South

Plessy v. Ferguson (1896) 'separate but equal' doctrine

Systematic Black disenfranchisement — poll taxes, literacy tests, white primaries, intimidation

During

Legal strategy in the courts (NAACP Legal Defense Fund; Brown v. Board, 1954)

Nonviolent direct action — boycotts, sit-ins, Freedom Rides, marches

Grassroots organizing (SCLC, SNCC, CORE, NAACP) and youth leadership

Federal intervention prompted by protest and violence (Little Rock; Selma → Voting Rights Act)

After

Landmark federal law: Civil Rights Act (1964), Voting Rights Act (1965), Fair Housing Act (1968)

A sharp rise in Black voter registration and officeholding, especially in the South

Persistent limits: de facto segregation, economic inequality, and later rollbacks (Shelby County v. Holder, 2013)

Changed significantly

The legal status of segregation and voting: federal law made de jure

Changed gradually

Actual desegregation of schools and public life, and the growth of

Stayed mostly the same

De facto segregation and deep economic disparities in housing,

segregation and discriminatory

Black political participation — over —

wealth and schooling persisted.....

voting tests illegal.

years, not overnight.

despite legal change.

Was this event truly a turning point? Use evidence from at least two sources.

Why did some conditions change quickly (the law on paper) while others changed slowly or barely at all (everyday economic and residential realities)? What is the difference between de jure and de facto change?

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3

Compare

- Compare your ledgers with a partner. Did you sort the same items into 'changed' vs. 'stayed the same'?
- Where did you disagree about whether something changed a lot, a little, or not at all?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

The movement changed the law decisively (Brown; the 1964, 1965, and 1968 Acts) while everyday desegregation and economic equality changed slowly or remained out of reach. The de jure / de facto distinction is the analytical heart of the lesson: legal change and lived change are related but not identical. Present tactics (litigation and nonviolent direct action) and federal responses as prompted by grassroots pressure.

Common misconceptions

- Laws did not instantly end segregation; enforcement and de facto segregation persisted.
- The movement was a broad, organized, grassroots effort, not the work of a few famous individuals alone.
- Gains were later contested (e.g., *Shelby County v. Holder*, 2013, weakened the Voting Rights Act).

Vocabulary

de jure, de facto, segregation, disenfranchisement, nonviolent direct action, Jim Crow, Brown v. Board, filibuster.

Historical context

Brown v. Board (1954); Montgomery Bus Boycott (1955–56); Little Rock (1957); Greensboro sit-ins (1960); March on Washington (1963); Civil Rights Act (1964); Voting Rights Act (1965); Fair Housing Act (1968).

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Was 1954–1968 a genuine turning point, or the acceleration of a longer struggle? Use evidence from at least two sources, cite specific laws or events, and address at least one way change was incomplete.